CASE STUDY

A Mother's 32-Year Wait

Sukhwant Kaur lost her son, husband and father in the space of a month in 1992

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



Sukhwant Kaur, son Jaswinder Singh

Sukhwant Kaur, 88, cannot ever forget the autumn of 1992, the season she lost the three men who anchored her life—her father, husband and a son. "In a woman's life," she says quietly, "three men are most important...I lost all three in one month." Her ordeal began in late October 1992 in Khandwala, a suburban area of Amritsar, when a posse of policemen led by then SHO Chabal Surender Pal Singh picked up Kaur's husband, Sukhdev Singh, and her 80-year-old father, Sulakhan Singh. They were not the target; the police were after her elder son, Baljinder Singh. An electrical engineer, the police suspected he was part of a militant organisation involved in several killings.

What followed shattered a family with deep roots in public service. The paternal grandfather had retired from Punjab Police, Sulakhan was a veteran freedom fighter, and Sukhdev himself was a respected educator. None of that insulated them from suspicion. "We kept chasing the cops for more information, but got nothing," says Sukhwant's younger son Jaswinder Singh. The family later learnt that Sukhdev and Sulakhan had died in police custody (the latter was allegedly dumped in the river alive with his hands tied). According to the prosecution case accepted by the court, both bodies were disposed of in the Sutlej river. Years later, they also learnt that Baljinder was killed in an alleged fake encounter in November 1992. Investigators concluded that his body had been secretly cremated at the Durgiana Temple crematorium in Amritsar.

For the next 32 years, Sukhwant Kaur pursued the case through commissions, investigators and courts. Her persistence eventually culminated in a CBI court convicting former SHO Surender Pal and sentencing him to seven years' imprisonment in 2024. Yet even after the verdict, justice feels incomplete.

"I performed the *bhog* of my husband and father only after the court judgment," she says. "I just have one last wish. I want these policemen to tell me which side of the Sutlej bank they threw their bodies. I just want to go there once... and cry before I die." ■

Tarn Taran. Sahni calls this loose estimate, presented as fact, as "akin to taking fatalities at Delhi's most dangerous crossing and multiplying by every traffic light in the city".

Director Trehan dismisses the criticism as hypocrisy. "If they feel *Satluj* is a one-sided story, they are absolutely free to make a film on the other side," he tells INDIA TODAY (see interview, "*My film has united Punjab...*"). "Nobody can tell me what I am supposed to make. *Kashmir Files ka bhi doosra* side *hoga*, *Kerala Story ka bhi hoga* (both films would have another side). I am not against these films. But if their freedom of expression is welcomed, why not mine?" He says the film does include scenes referencing the region's violent past.

Having spent a better part of his childhood in Tarn Taran, Trehan calls the film—built around a man he equates

TERRORISM EXPERT AJAI SAHNI BELIEVES KHALRA SHOULD NOT BE CALLED A HUMAN RIGHTS ACTIVIST, BUT AN OVERGROUND WORKER OR A TERRORIST ASSOCIATE